

Popularity

It makes no sense to buy a phone just because 2 million people have pre-ordered it in a few hours. If most of your friends are on BlackBerry Messenger, you might as well consider a BlackBerry, if the idea is to be in touch with friends 24x7. The same holds true for iMessage or FaceTime for the iPhone. These are just examples of how you need to understand which phone/platform will suit you best.

Recommendations

Apple iPhone 4S

At the time of writing this, the iPhone 5 has not been announced in India, which is why the 4S is still the top of the line iPhone retailing in the country. Still pretty much the second-in-command benchmark, and has competed successfully with even the most powerful Android phones.

Samsung Galaxy SIII

Arguably the most powerful Android phone money can buy. Need we say more? Well, all the rubbish about pentile displays doesn't bother us – this one is vivid, crisp, bright and not very reflective. Quite well-built too, and the battery life of a day-and-a-half to two days is excellent.

Sony Xperia S

This is retailing for around ₹28,000, and has been updated to Android ICS. The build quality is excellent, and various design elements do well to make this stand out in a crowd. We've seen very good performance from this dual-core phone, and the battery life has been improved with the new OS.

considering, let us help you pick the right piece of equipment that justifies the money you spend on it.

Stuff that matters

Focal length and zoom

There are a few features that make your camera a good investment. The first is the focal length, or simply put, how wide and far the camera lens can see. However, advertising focuses on zoom ratings more, and this is rated as a number followed by an X, such as 4X or 10X or 40X, etc. A higher "X" number doesn't make the lens better, as this number is attained by dividing the farthest your lens can go by the widest it can see. So a 25-250mm lens rates at 10x and so does a lens that goes from 20-200mm. When looking at a camera, consider a lens that has a lower starting number. 24mm is ideal, but the lower the better.

Aperture

Another aspect of the lens that generally goes completely ignored is the aperture. A smaller aperture number means that the lens can gather more light. The smaller this number, the better the camera will do in low light. Now there are quite a few point and shoots out there that have aperture number of f/2.8 or lower, but that number changes as you zoom farther through the focal range. So the best lens would be one which maintains a small aperture number even when zoomed in all the way. So, when you see f/1.8-5.6 against f/1.8-2.5, know that the former won't do so well in low light when you're zoomed in, but the latter will. So the smart thing would be to get a camera with a fast minimum aperture on one end, but it would be ways smarter to get one with low aperture on both ends of the focal length.

Sensor

The third important thing to look into is the sensor. Now traditionally, we'd say that anything above 12-14 megapixels isn't adding any value to your image quality, but things have changed greatly in the last few years. Now we have something known as Back-Side Illuminated (BSI) sensors, which, by virtue of their design, are better at keeping noise at bay, therefore allowing better low light performance and the ability to pack in more megapixels without compromising quality. So if your camera has a BSI sensor, you should be set.

Format

Since this is all about image quality, cameras that record photographs in their RAW formats (instead of just JPG) would definitely be on the top of our to buy list.

Battery

The last, but equally important thing about camera specifications you should keep an eye out for is the battery capacity. There is nothing worse than being at an important event, trying to capture the moment and watching your camera battery die. Well, running out of room on your memory card could be worse, but the battery thing is pretty infuriating too. While the battery life shouldn't be the deciding factor in your final choice of camera (the images matter more), the smart thing would be to pick up a pair of extra batteries and keep them charged at all times.

The not-so-important stuff

Pixels

If a sales person says "Sir! This camera has more pixels, so it's better", start backing away slowly, and make no sudden movements, this breed is known to attack! Even with BSI sensors, a higher pixel count stops to matter. If you're a pixel-peeper, then you're probably looking at a full frame DSLR, but if point-and-shoots are your realm, then anything between 12-18 megapixels is just fine. Even big prints can be made from this pixel count. So buy smart and don't shell out extra money for a high megapixel camera, or worse, shell choose a camera that lacks the important stuff, but has a larger pixel count.

DECISION TIME CAMERAS

The urge to splurge on new gadgets is understandable, but often not justified. So if you're caught in the conundrum of whether you should shell out that hard earned cash on a new camera, we'll make it easy for you. If you bought your camera in the last one year, and it was the newest model at the time, then you don't need to upgrade. If you bought your equipment two years ago (new at the time), then upgrading at this moment is more a matter of whether you can afford the luxury or not. If your camera is three years or older, then this Diwali might be a good time to upgrade.



The buying season is upon us and the market is being flooded with deals. Now would be a good time to consider upgrading your trusted camera, whether it's a point and shoot or your DSLR. If it's something you're already